

Funny Names, Faithful God

Isaiah 62:1-5

For Zion's sake I will not keep silent, for Jerusalem's sake I will not remain quiet, till her vindication shines out like the dawn, her salvation like a blazing torch. The nations will see your vindication, and all kings your glory; you will be called by a new name that the mouth of the Lord will bestow. You will be a crown of splendor in the Lord's hand, a royal diadem in the hand of your God. No longer will they call you Deserted, or name your land Desolate. But you will be called Hephzibah, and your land Beulah; for the Lord will take delight in you, and your land will be married. As a young man marries a young woman, so will your Builder marry you; as a bridegroom rejoices over his bride, so will your God rejoice over you.

In the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit. Amen.

Which of the following names do you think are towns in Michigan:

New Mexico

Truth or Consequences

Kalamazoo

Funny sounding as they may be, all of them are names of towns in Michigan. You may know someone with a different—maybe even funny-sounding name. If so, you have probably wondered what that name means.

Today's Bible reading has two funny-sounding names. They are Hephzibah and Beulah. They sound funny to us because they are Hebrew names. Hephzibah is a name for the Jewish people, God's chosen nation, and it probably makes you wonder, "What does Hephzibah even mean?" Beulah is a name for the land that Israel lived in, and it probably makes you wonder, "How did it get to be called that?"

God himself gave these names to his people and their land. Hephzibah means, "My delight is in her." Beulah means, "married." God gave these names to reflect his love for his people. Even though Israel kept on disobeying him and not trusting in him, God promised to remain faithful to Israel because he loved them.

Think about the way that you name your pets or how you named your stuffed animals when you were younger. Naming a pet or a stuffed animal was your way of establishing a relationship with that pet or that stuffed animal because you cared about it.

Now, what kind of relationship could sinners like you and I expect to have with the holy, eternal God? We sinners might expect to be his slaves because he is the King. We might hope to be friends with God. But God exceeds our expectations! We are more than servants of the King.

We are more than just friends of the true God. God has made us his family! Or, as Isaiah put it, God has married himself to us because that's how much God loves us!

So, you could go around calling yourself "Hephzibah." Then, when people ask you about that funny-sounding name, you could tell them, "It's because God delights in me." You could ask your pastor to name your church property "Buelah" because God promises to stay faithful to his church, like a husband stays faithful to his wife.

You could make a case for those names, but maybe it's just easier for you to live your life trusting this. You have the name "Christian." And because of Jesus Christ, God rejoices over you and delights in you.

The questions below are to help families discuss this devotion. The questions are divided by age group as suggestions, but anyone could reflect on any of the questions as they desire.

Questions for the Younger Children

- God compares the way that he feels about you to the way that people feel at a wedding. How do people feel at a wedding?
- God promises to save his people. What does he save us from?

Questions for Elementary Age Children

- Why did God care so much about Jerusalem?
- How does it make you feel to know that God says you are like a prized possession in his hand?

Questions for Middle School and Above

- God said that he was giving a new name to the land of Israel. Can you think of other people in the Bible who received new names from God?
- God compares his relationship with his believers to a marriage. People get married because they love each other. What is the proof that God loves you?

Closing Prayer:

Gracious God, because you delight in us, make us delight in you and your word. Make our words and actions shine in our lives that others may see your glory and trust in your salvation. Amen.